

When America walks away | For decades America has enjoyed hegemony over the Middle East. That is about to end

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文章概览: For decades America has enjoyed hegemony over the Middle East. That is about to end

- AMERICA SEEMS to be stuck in the Middle East. It has no easy way out of its war with Iran. Yet the conflict, however it ends, will in fact mark something quite different: the moment when America pulls back from the region—in the sense that it finally relinquishes its hegemony there. For the first time since the great powers dismembered the Ottoman empire a century ago, the Middle East's overarching order will no longer be imposed from afar. Will that herald an orgy of score-settling and violence, or a new beginning?
- Since the first world war, the birthplace of the world's three great monotheistic religions has suffered misery heaped upon misery. Arabs who had fought alongside the war's victors felt betrayed when Britain took control of Iraq, Jordan and Palestine, and France helped itself to Lebanon and Syria. Nationalist leaders, including Gamal Abdel Nasser of Egypt, later fell under the spell of ruinous Soviet-inspired economic policies. The staggering abuse of human rights by dictators such as Saddam Hussein in Iraq and Hafez al-Assad in Syria was matched only by the violent fanaticism of the jihadists nourished by their sadistic rule.
- After three wars, countless covert operations and seemingly endless rounds of diplomacy, America's attempts to impose its designs have run their course. Like Britain, France and Russia, America will still be involved. It will occasionally use military force to pursue its interests, including for counter-terrorism. But it will abandon its role as architect.

Leaders | The Middle East

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The signs of America's looming retrenchment are unmistakable—even as President Donald Trump uses the annual meeting of the UN to threaten Iran with "annihilation" for the umpteenth time. Two stand out. Earlier this month America declined to join its ally Saudi Arabia in striking the Houthis in Yemen, who are endangering shipping in the Red Sea. Instead it held talks behind the Saudis' backs to spare American vessels from attack. That may seem like a detail, but when a superpower does deals with an insurgent militia, everyone understands it wants to cut its commitments.

The other sign is the expectation that America will limit its presence in the Middle East. In peacetime it has 30,000-40,000 troops on 19 bases, eight of which are permanent. However, the war has exposed how vulnerable they are to drones and cheap missiles. America has therefore been obliged to depend on aircraft-carriers and its Indian Ocean base on Diego Garcia. Some experts are arguing that it should concentrate its forces in a few places, such as Israel and Jordan.

This fits a broader realignment in which, as NBC reported this month, 25,000-40,000 American troops could be pulled out of Europe, too. The Trump administration is focused on the Americas. Securocrats want to equip America for the growing rivalry with China which, as this week's Trump-Xi summit shows, teeters between wary co-existence and outright hostility. Neither goal is advanced by Middle Eastern wars that empty America's arsenals and suck its forces out of Asia.

And to what end? Until 2020 America was an oil importer; today it is a colossal exporter. China, by contrast, has become Gulf producers' biggest customer, and the Suez canal carries its goods to European markets. That makes China the great external beneficiary of America's policies. But it is unlikely to try to step in as the Middle Eastern hegemon—not when it has seen the trillions of dollars and thousands of lives America has paid for the privilege.

Instead, three of the region's countries have the heft to begin to fill the vacuum—and none of them is Arab. The most dangerous is Iran. If the regime in Tehran collapses, it will be in no position to rebuild its malign influence across Iraq, Syria and Lebanon. If, as is likely, it survives, it will hope to extract rents by controlling the Strait of Hormuz and bullying the Gulf states that it has attacked in the war. It will also try to rebuild its militias abroad. It may well restart work on a nuclear weapon, which will surely remain a red line for America. In all this, it may receive Russian backing.

The second regional power is Turkey, which has been quietly building closer relations with Arab countries. It has become the main supporter of the new government in Syria. With Iraq, it is working on trade routes, water supplies and countering Kurdish separatists. Last month it signed a security agreement with Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. Although it has championed the Muslim Brotherhood, it is more pragmatic than ideological, seeking business for its defence industry and construction firms.

The third is Israel, the dominant military and intelligence power. After the massacres of October 7th 2023 it sees itself as a modern Sparta, seeking to destroy any capability that might threaten it. Under the Abraham accords, it has forged close ties with the United Arab Emirates, even as the prospect of a deal with the Palestinians has faded.

These three countries are unlikely to live with each other in peace. Israel and Turkey are already at loggerheads in Syria. Israel and Iran have unfinished business over the war. Iran and Turkey are ancient imperial rivals.

The losers are the Arab states. Countries such as Iraq and Syria are still struggling to emerge from the ashes of civil war. Egypt, once the natural leader of the Arab world, devotes its energy to corruption and crushing opposition at home. The Gulf monarchies have embraced a prosperity agenda that seeks to anaesthetise ideology with economic growth. That is welcome, but their business model depends on American security. The rivalries of ultra-rich Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE are radiating instability—perhaps America’ s parting gift could be to help them work together.

Arabs have long yearned for a chance to recover lost glory from when they were a beacon of science and learning centuries ago. America’ s retrenchment is about to give them a chance. But each departing hegemon has left a legacy of frustrated designs and unintended consequences. There remain deep hatreds and unsettled scores. The Middle East will struggle to prove the doubters wrong. ■